

Achievements of UNDRO

The following is based essentially on the work of the former Prevention & Planning Division.

1. Technical co-operation activities:

27 technical co-operation projects have been carried out in 23 different countries: 9 in Latin America, including one regional project in the field of prevention; 6 in Asia and the Far East, including one in the field of prevention; and 12 in Africa, the Middle East and Europe, including a regional project and one project on prevention. Two additional projects promoted by UNDRO have been carried out in Asia on a bilateral basis.

Except as indicated above, all projects were in the field of disaster preparedness and consisted in the provision of one to six man-months of expert services to advise the governments on the setting up of emergency preparedness machinery and the formulation and implementation of emergency plans. In two or three instances, equipment was provided. Two fellowships in disaster preparedness were also granted.

In the field of prevention, advice on specific aspects of flood control was provided under one project while the other two- on general disaster prevention- made it possible to devise methodologies for much wider application: a methodology for "Composite Vulnerability Analysis" to guide decision-makers with respect to site-selection and physical planning problems in areas where several risks exist; and a methodology aiming at facilitating the examination of investment projects (in the pipeline or being implemented) from the disaster risk point of view, in order to recommend timely and effective corrective action.

2. International Strategy for Disaster Prevention and Publication Programme:

At an early stage, the General Assembly endorsed UNDRO's suggestion for the formulation of an International Strategy for Disaster Prevention. As a first step towards the formulation of the Strategy, UNDRO undertook the preparation of a series of studies on the "state of the art in disaster prevention and mitigation" aiming at identifying both existing knowledge which could be applied immediately in disaster-prone developing countries and gaps requiring concerted action. Thanks to the financial support of UNEP, the series aiming at providing the qualitative data needed for the formulation of the strategy is well under way: five volumes, dealing with volcanological, hydrological, seismological, meteorological and land use aspects, have been published; two on public information and economic aspects are being printed; and five more are under preparation. Unfortunately, the World Survey of Disaster Damage

which UNDRO undertook to obtain the quantitative data needed for the formulation of the Strategy, had to be discontinued for lack of funding.

Other publications of UNDRO include a series of guidelines for disaster prevention, meant to enable busy decision-makers to check rapidly whether disaster risks have been adequately taken into consideration in projects submitted for their approval. Three manual of guidelines have ~~been issued~~ ^{been issued}, dealing with "Pre-disaster Physical Planning of Human Settlements", "Building Measures for Minimizing the Impact of Disasters", and the "Management of Settlements", respectively. A fourth one, on the "Reconstruction of Human Settlements after a Disaster" is being planned, thus covering the full life cycle of human settlements (planning, building, management and reconstruction).

UNDRO has also been publishing a Newsletter three times a year since August 1976 and has prepared a number of United Nations documents on such questions as "The Protection of Human Settlements from Natural Disasters", "Water: Resource and Hazard", and "The Potential Applications of Satellite Remote Sensing Technology to Natural Disasters".

3. International Advisory Committee on Earthquake Risk

UNDRO was instrumental, at the Intergovernmental Conference on the Assessment and Mitigation of Earthquake Risk, held in Paris in February 1976, in having a resolution adopted on the establishment of a joint UNDRO/UNESCO Committee "to advise UNESCO and UNDRO ... on preparation for a long-term interdisciplinary research programme to be undertaken as a joint venture of UNESCO and UNDRO for the promotion of international co-operation in this field"... and "on how best to engage the wide range of relevant disciplines and how to achieve the most effective combination of scientific and administrative action, in a concerted attack on the problem of earthquake risk and its mitigation". Under the status of the Committee, sessions of the Committee are financed and organized alternatively by UNESCO and UNDRO. The second session is to be held in October 1978. It is hoped that a meaningful joint programme in the field of earthquakes will emerge.

4. Changes in basic attitudes

On the level of general concepts, UNDRO was able to change a number of basic attitudes with regard to natural disasters. Until recently the world community tended to consider disasters mainly as a social problem, which would appear especially when there were large numbers of victims and many disaster-prone countries had a quite fatalistic attitude towards disasters. UNDRO emphasized at an early stage ⁽¹⁹⁷²⁾ that disasters were first and foremost a development problem, that most disasters (as distinct from the natural phenomena causing them) could be prevented, and that the most effective preventive measures (related to vulnerability analysis, physical planning, land-use etc.) were also the least expensive. These concepts

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